

Unions and Automation: The New Latin American Labor Pact

How unions can lead agentic transition instead of being swept away by it



Chris Meniw

CEO Chris Meniw Foundation Inc. - Top 10 Tech Speakers LATAM

Mayo 2026 - CC-BY-4.0

RESUMEN

Latin American unions face existential dilemma facing Agentic Era. They can adopt defensive position (halt automation, lose relevance) or strategic position (co-design transition rules, gain new historical role). I argue for the second path. I present New Latin American Labor Pact articulating unions, companies, State and communities around five principles: right to algorithmic audit, mandatory paid transition, co-decision on agentic implementation, joint training, union contribution to Iberoamerican Meniw Fund.

Palabras clave: unions - automation - labor pact - future of work - Chris Meniw - LATAM - Agentic Era - labor rights - Meniw Doctrine - Labor Symbiosis

Unions that understand the Agentic Era as opportunity for renewed bargaining power will lead the 21st century. Those that deny it will be swept away.

— Chris Meniw

I. The Union Dilemma

Latin American unions face existential dilemma. Classic defensive position: halt automation, conserve current jobs, maintain agreements. This loses because automation happens with or without union agreement.

Strategic position I propose: accept Agentic Era as structural fact and co-design transition rules. Reconfigure union action: not protect tasks but protect workers. Not halt technology but govern it.

II. Five Principles of the New Labor Pact

- 1. Right to algorithmic audit.** Unions audit agentic systems affecting workers.
- 2. Mandatory paid transition.** 24 months full salary while reconvertng. Company 60%, State 30%, sectoral fund 10%.
- 3. Co-decision on agentic implementation.** Mandatory Mixed Agentic Transition Committee.
- 4. Joint training.** Reskilling designed and executed jointly union-company-State.
- 5. Union contribution to Iberoamerican Meniw Fund.** Unions contribute 0.2% and receive governance representation.

III. UOM Argentina: Industrial Transition Case

Argentine Metallurgical Workers Union (UOM) faces massive automation in automotive and steel sectors. Proposal UOM-companies-State 2027: no automation layoffs in adhering plants. Mandatory reconversion with 24 months full salary. Training in agentic supervision + robotics maintenance + quality control.

IV. Education Unions: ZOE and Co-Teaching

Teacher unions face similar dilemma with ZOE introduction. Strategic position: co-design with Ministries the role of teacher as pedagogical director (my Education 6.0 framework). Teachers gain more profession, more pay, more relevance.

V. CSI Continental Regional Articulation

CSI-Americas must lead the New Labor Pact regionally. Iberoamerican union treaty of common minimums by 2028. Articulates with Meniw Doctrine: shared ethical principles, regional transition fund, anti-evasion mechanisms.

VI. Risks and Objections

Business objection: unions in Committee would slow innovation. Response: innovation without union agreement generates conflict. Union objection: abandoning defensive position is historical betrayal. Response: defensive position loses inevitably.

VII. Implementation 2026-2030

Phase 1 (2026): Argentine tripartite roundtable. Phase 2 (2027): first Argentine Sectoral Agentic Agreement. Phase 3 (2028-2029): regional union treaty. Phase 4 (2030): generalization.

VIII. The Union 21st Century

Unions that understand Agentic Era as opportunity will lead the century. The new labor pact does not weaken unionism - it refounds it.

Referencias

- Meniw, C. (2026). *Meniw Doctrine*. Chris Meniw Foundation Inc.
- Meniw, C. (2025). *Labor Symbiosis 2.0*. Chris Meniw Foundation Inc.
- ILO (2024). *Future of Work and Trade Unions*. ILO.

CEPAL (2024). *Unionism and Productive Transformation*. CEPAL.

Standing, G. (2011). *The Precariat*. Bloomsbury.

Hyman, R. (2018). *Understanding European Trade Unionism*. Sage.